



Stop triggering Siri

It is easy to trigger Siri by pressing a button for a second too long, here is how to prevent that. <http://dgit.in/sep20-1>



Alexa on your phone

There are some solid reasons to install Alexa on your device, even though it comes with an assistant. <http://dgit.in/sep20-2>

Voice assistants hit the lab bench

Transforming modern-day voice assistants into a tool for scientists and researchers

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“A

lexa, play my rock playlist”, “Alexa, what’s the weather like?”, “Alexa, what’s my schedule like

today?”. These are voice commands we are accustomed to the intelligent voice assistants having significant levels of proficiency in. However, most of us won’t intuitively picture Alexa in scientific, research-intensive settings, such as assisting a scientist or researcher with their lab work. But, the once perceived high-tech frill is now actually paving its path to becoming an even more serious technology, going from a fantasy we developed from watching the HAL 9000 computer in 2001: Space Odyssey, to an actual fact-based scientific tool. How so, you may ask? Through the advent and development of voice-activated laboratory assistants.

It’s not tech giants such as Amazon, Google, or Apple that are pursuing this, but laboratory informatics firms that have begun integrating voice assistants into electronic laboratory notebooks, (ELNs), laboratory information management systems (LIMs), and even the common lab instruments. These firms have had to meander through seemingly treacherous paths, in order to, sort of, ‘upgrade’ the assistant to another level where it

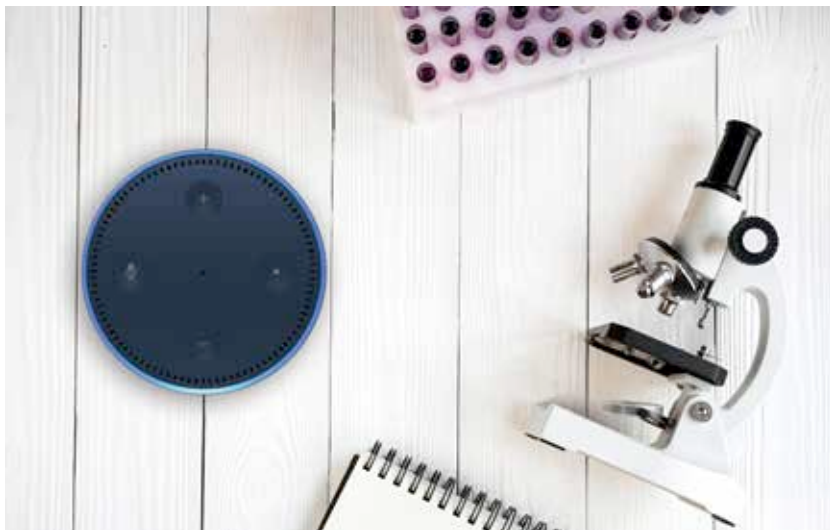
becomes a scientifically viable tool for researchers and scientists.

Natural language processing (NLP) programs have to be tweaked extensively to allow these assistants to be able to recognise all the chemical names, technical jargon used in labs, remember catalogues of lab products, and hordes of chemical reactions. Additionally, the technology has to be able to connect to gadgets far more technical than the usual coffee makers or smart refrigerators. We’re talking chromatography and mass spectrometry instruments, for example. In order to make the life of researchers and scientists easier in the lab and allow them to work essentially handsfree, the voice assistant-powered tools we’re seeing being developed for labs can record voice notes and transcribe them, dictate instructions for chemical procedures such as titration, and even answer questions. Let’s look at a few examples.

HELIXAI

An Atlanta startup, HelixAI, founded by husband-wife duo, software devel-

oper James Rhodes and microbiologist DeLacy Rhodes, has been working extensively on transmorphing Alexa into a voice-activated lab assistant since 2017. The founders figured it would be beneficial to scientists and researchers working in labs, to say, have an experimental procedure read aloud to them while their hands are gloved and busy. To this end, James Rhodes developed an Alexa app called Helix. The company was reportedly one of nine software development firms that were accepted into an Amazon accelerator



Founders of Helix AI, DeLacy and James Rhodes

Credit: William Graves Photography